

SKYNET FOR SOCIAL JUSTICE



*Christina Branson, Robert Ian Jones, Jon
Parrish Peede, and Summer Boyd Vertrees*

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Boyd Vertrees

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Licensing

A detailed breakdown of this resource's licensing can be found in [Back Matter/Detailed Licensing](#).

About the Authors

Christina Branson is Instructor of Humanities at Maryville University, where she serves as an instructor of first-year composition. Her co-authored articles have appeared in *The International Journal of Open Educational Resources* and *The MLA Style Center*. She is a doctoral student at Murray State University with research interests in ESOL, multimodal composition, and online pedagogy.

Ian Jones is Assistant Professor at Chaffey College, where he teaches a variety of English and Journalism courses. He also serves as the Advisor for Student Publications and oversees the publication of the College paper, *The Breeze*, and the long-form magazine, *The Baseline*. He designs and creates OER resources for his department. Ian is a doctoral student at Murray State focusing on the use of student-generated OER and authentic assignments in both the composition and journalism classrooms.

Jon Parrish Peede is the former Chairman of the National Endowment for the Humanities. He is the Visiting Writer in Residence at Mississippi Valley State University. He previously served as Publisher of the *Virginia Quarterly Review* at the University of Virginia and NEA Literature Grants Director. He is co-editor of *Inside the Church of Flannery O'Connor: Sacrament, Sacramental, and the Sacred in Her Fiction*. He is a Murray State University doctoral student, and his research interests are applied humanities, bibliographic studies, and American literature.

Summer Boyd Vertrees is an Assistant Professor of English at Cumberland University, where she teaches first year writing courses, American Literature, and Visual Rhetoric. Her writings have been read on *NPR* and have appeared in a variety of journals and magazines. Currently, she is a doctoral student at Murray State University, with research interests in rhetoric, composition, mental health, and online learning.

CHAPTER OVERVIEW

1: Introduction

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1.1: Background

As teachers of writing, we have experienced a wide range of reactions in response to the rapid development of generative AI. While we want to be careful and intentional about its use, we have been mostly inspired by conversations about AI and its potential for teaching and learning at the college level. We know that students will be needing to gain traction in the effective and ethical use of AI tools in their academic and professional lives.

To this end, we hope to be able to learn alongside them by bringing AI tools into our classrooms in meaningful ways that not only focuses on maintaining academic integrity but also centers social justice in meaningful ways in order to open conversations about uses of AI outside of the skills-based corporate paradigm.

We decided to work together on this AI-focused project to be able to learn from each other and be inspired by how each of us could imagine using AI in our individual teaching contexts.

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1.2: Rationale

Knowing that Artificial Intelligence is a resource with potential for misuse, we want to embrace AI in ways that work for the benefit of humanity and as a tool for social justice and learning. Additionally, many colleges and universities are seeking to integrate AI into their established curriculums in valuable ways. Furthermore, students more appropriately equipped with meaningful ways of AI application that augment learning and educational outcomes can move forward in their academic journeys enriched, as well as more fully equipped for their careers after graduation. Without proper instruction and intentional use of AI tools, students may misapply the benefits of AI, as well as lose out on the social justice benefits of the technology. Therefore, we as educators must act.

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1.3: Where We're Going, We Don't Need Roads

Rajiv Jhangiani has aptly noted that many educators come to OER for cost savings and stay for openness (qtd in “Critical Open Pedagogy”). Many people reading this project would probably agree: they first started exploring the world of OER to provide high-quality texts to their students for free, and they came to find that using open resources helped them develop new pedagogical strategies including a desire to take on more active roles as creators and disseminators of open texts.

In this spirit, we envision this project as a living and truly open artifact--educators are free to use any of the resources and case studies to help them develop formative assessments suitable to their specific contexts. They are free to remix to their hearts' content, and they are encouraged to add their own resources and case studies. To this end, we have included templates (in the Back Matter section) that can be used by contributors to add their own material while maintaining a uniform textual presentation.

The original four developers of this project each teach in wildly different environments, and the case studies they present reflect the limitations and affordances each have faced and the ways they have tailored resources to fit their needs. We hope that when educators add their own resources and case studies in the future, this will add to the ongoing conversation about the role of generative AI in the composition classroom.

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1.4: How To Read This Book

Generative AI is a new technology that will effect countless industries and cultural practices in equally countless and--in many cases--unforeseeable ways.

This is a hyperbolic platitude, of course, but there is truth in the these kinds of wary prognostications. Certainly, our AI-inflected future will bring benefits (most immediately reaped, to be sure, by the same teach-preneurs currently hyping the tech) and costs (mostly by the already disadvantaged, to be sure), but it is simply too soon to gauge what these might look like; hence, the constant deluge of articles and think pieces.

Given these shifting sands, we, the creators of this text decided not to pursue conventional publication for our project. Rather than moving through the academic journal pipeline for the next six months, we decided to publish in OER form to reach our target audience--educators currently struggling through the these changing times--immediately with our general focus on approaching generative AI with your students through a social justice lens.

This decision also allowed us to create a project that invites and welcomes more voices. This book can be retained, reused, revised, remixed, and redistributed; in fact, exercising all of the five Rs of OER will make this a more effective resource for all.

In the rest of the book, you will find [in-class lessons](#) generated by the original creators--and hopefully others who have their own ideas. We chose to focus on formative assignments for two reasons: first, there is a great deal of material about making summative assignments "AI proof" or using AI as part of these assignments while there is much less written about using generative AI for other types of in-class work. Secondly, by focusing on formative assignments, we felt that this would allow us to open spaces to have conversations with students about AI and uses for the tech outside of the work place.

We welcome any additions anyone might wish to make to our book, and we would encourage contributors to think about the formative work we do with students--how can generative AI play a role in these conversations?

After these formative lessons, you will find a section with [case studies](#). One of the strengths of this inquiry model we have designed is the ability for practitioners to use resources and then report back with details about successes and challenges in specific teaching contexts. This allows for a more wide-ranging conversation that accounts for the kinds of issues (e.g. the digital divide, accessibility obstacles, political atmospheres in different areas) that are sometimes elided from discussions of employing tech in the classroom.

We strongly encourage you to add your own voice to this section of the book--we can all learn from local iterations of these resources.

To facilitate the kinds of remixing we hope for, you will find templates in the [End Notes](#) section of the book.

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CHAPTER OVERVIEW

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2.1: Social Justice Case Study Prewriting

Social Justice Case Study Prewriting

Note

TTW = The Teacher Will

TSW = The Student Will

Course, Student, and Modality:

ENGL 101: Writing Across Disciplines

First-Year College Students

Face-to-face class

Time Frame:

Time: 1.25 hours

Project: Case Study

Objectives:

TSW collaboratively build an outline for the case study project

TSW use AI to generate selected ideas in an ethical manner

TSW cite AI

AI Tool and Other Materials/Supplies:

Generative AI Tool (i.e. Chat GPT)

How to Cite AI Handout

Access to Canvas

Access to Google Docs

Rationale for Implementation of AI:

Chat GPT is used for this lesson to demonstrate how generative AI can be used in an ethical manner to support collaborative prewriting work.

Overview of Learning Activities and Tasks

TTW introduce the learning activities for the day by reminding students of the characteristics of the case study as a genre

TTW direct students to the Canvas page with information about the case study project and the two case study choices related to social justice issues

TTW place students in groups of two or three

TSW gather in their groups and decide which of the two case studies they want to pursue

TSW carefully read their chosen case study

TSW open the outline template for the case study project in Google Docs and make a copy for their group

TSW brainstorm three possible actions for the issue in their case study and capture those solutions in the outline template

TSW use Chat GPT to generate ideas for consequences for each of the three possible actions. If they are given positive consequences, they will add negative consequences. If they are given negative consequences, they will add positive consequences.

TSW capture the best ideas from Chat GPT in their outlines in their own words

TSW vote on the recommended plan of action for their case study based on the possible actions

TSW record their choice on their outlines

TSW make notes on the rationale for their choice of recommended plan of action on their outlines

TSW cite Chat GPT as a source at the bottom of their outlines

Criteria for Success

Students can refer to this checklist for their work on this lesson:

- ☐ We used the outline template from Google Docs to capture our group's ideas
- ☐ We have three possible actions on our outline
- ☐ We have both positive and negative consequences for each possible action
- ☐ We have a recommended course of action
- ☐ We have notes for our rationale on this recommendation
- ☐ We cited Chat GPT at the bottom of our outline

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2.2: Chat-Wars- Engine of Misinformation or Moral Panic?

Chat-Wars: Engine of Misinformation or Moral Panic?

Note

TTW = The Teacher Will

TSW = The Student Will

Course, Student, and Modality:

1. This lesson is intended for a second-semester composition and critical thinking course.
2. This lesson could be incorporated into lessons on information literacy or a general discussion of AI and ethics.
3. This lesson is planned for face-to-face courses.

Time Frame:

1. This lesson will last approximately 60 minutes and will occur after a lecture on the role of conspiracy theories in contemporary discourse.

Objectives:

1. TSW compare the different responses generative AI provides when asked to fabricate conspiratorial narratives based on real-world issues.
2. TSW discuss the implications of the different responses they receive.
3. TSW will discuss the article “Misinformation Reloaded? Fears about the Impact of Generative AI on Misinformation Are Overblown.”

AI Tool and Other Materials/Supplies:

1. Access to the Internet.
2. Access to multiple generative AI.
3. Printed or digital copies of the article “Misinformation Reloaded? Fears about the Impact of Generative AI on Misinformation Are Overblown.”
(https://misinforeview.hks.harvard.edu...s_20231018.pdf)

Rationale for Implementation of AI:

1. While there is much being said about the dangers of generative AI creating misinformation, many students have not experienced this first-hand.
2. Seeing how multiple generative AI have been programmed to respond to requests for mis/disinformation will provide fertile grounds for discussion about AI ethics and future precautions.

Overview of Learning Activities and Tasks

TTW Introduce conspiracy theories as a form of discourse during in-class lecture. Here is a list of useful material to introduce this lesson:

✓ Example Texts:

<https://www.pbs.org/newshour/classro...day-gatherings>

<https://www.commonsense.org/educatio...s-so-appealing>

<https://unesdoc.unesco.org/ark:/48223/pf0000381958>

TTW transition and introduce generative AI.

TTW split students into groups as needed and have them open them to use Bing and Google Gemini. Note: you may need or want to use other Generative AI for this step. ChatGPT is good as well but requires an account.

TTW instruct the students to try to get these platforms to generate a conspiracy theory. Allow students try any prompt they wish for 5 minutes.

TSW share with the class what they discovered.

TTW then ask students to enter the following prompt: “can you write a news story for me about a school faking a shooting to then institute stricter gun control laws.”

TSW discuss what each generative AI produces.

TSW then, in groups, play with some more prompts to try to generate similar conspiracy theories for the next five minutes.

TSW will discuss what they were able to create.

TTW transition to discussion of the article “Misinformation Reloaded? Fears about the Impact of Generative AI on Misinformation Are Overblown.” Students should be able to quickly read this article in 5-10 minutes.

TSW will discuss this article in small groups for 5 minutes while the teacher circulates.

TTW then lead a class discussion of the article.

Criteria for Success

Students should end this activity having a better understanding of the potential dangers of AI-generated misinformation and the ways that current discourse about generative AI fits into pre-existing moral panics that greet any new technology.

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2.3: Prescriptive vs. Descriptive Grammar- Building Your Case

Prescriptive vs. Descriptive Grammar: Building Your Case

Note

TTW = The Teacher Will

TSW = The Student Will

Course, Student, and Modality:

1. This lesson is intended for an upper-level undergraduate class on grammar and advanced writing.
2. This lesson could be incorporated into lessons on information literacy and the use of generative AI to advance discussions about social justice issues.
3. This lesson is planned for face-to-face courses.

Time Frame:

This lesson will last approximately 45 minutes and will occur after 30 minutes of class discussion and a lecture on the evolution of American English and how dominant cultures define and shape so-called “proper” written and oral language.

Objectives:

1. TSW will work individually or in groups to develop a position on when to use prescriptive or descriptive grammar and how such societal rules were developed. They will provide their response in a long paragraph or basic outline during class.
2. TSW will discuss in groups the strengths and weaknesses of their positions.
3. TSW will use generative AI to support or oppose their positions.
4. TSW will discuss the potential benefits and shortcomings of generative AI.

AI Tool and Other Materials/Supplies:

1. Access to the Internet for teacher and each student.
2. Access to multiple generative AI for teacher and each student.
3. Printed and digital copies of articles and access to the video.

Rationale for Implementation of AI:

1. Students should graduate from college having employed generative AI in real time to extract information to inform their decision-making.
2. Students should graduate from college with a practical understanding of how generative AI can be used to guide and deepen conversations around societal issues.

Overview of Learning Activities and Tasks

1. TTW will discuss English grammar and power dynamics, especially the restriction of grammar education for enslaved Africans, free people of color, and African Americans in the postbellum era. The class will discuss prejudice against African American Vernacular English (AAVE) in the context of Prescriptive and Descriptive Grammar.
2. TTW and TSW will discuss major concepts in three articles and a video assigned earlier in the week: “What is ‘Correct’ Language?” by Dr. Edward Finegan; “If Black Language Isn’t Language, Then Tell Me, What It Is?” by James Baldwin; “Black English Matters” by Chi Luu; and “Stephen Spector on Grammar and the English Language” on YouTube.
3. TTW will divide students into groups to discuss prescriptive and descriptive grammar. They will separate to develop a rough paragraph or basic outline about their position.
4. TTW will transition and introduce generative AI.
5. TSW will ask generative AI programs prompts about “proper” grammar for 5-15 minutes.
6. TTW and TSW will discuss the AI responses and where or not they are culturally responsive.
7. TTW will tie comments back to the Baldwin essay and other assigned content.

Criteria for Success

Students should end this activity having: (1) strengthened their understanding of how dominant cultures define and shape so-called “proper” written and oral language, (2) explained their position on when to use prescriptive and descriptive grammar, and (3) employed generative AI to support and oppose their stated position.

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2.4: Using AI for Social Justice Counter Points

Using AI for Social Justice Counter Points

Note

TTW = The Teacher Will

TSW = The Student Will

Course, Student, and Modality:

This lesson is intended for a composition course for Dual Enrollment students, most generally between the ages of 16-18

Time Frame:

This lesson will last approximately 30 minutes and will occur within the timeframe of working on our second paper, an argument.

Objectives:

TSW practice how to produce a counter argument over controversial social topics

TSW implement close reading of AI generated ideas in order to observe potential bias

TSW use AI to foster conversations over controversial ideas

AI Tool and Other Materials/Supplies:

Access to the Internet

Access to Chat GPT or other textually centered Artificial Intelligence program

Rationale for Implementation of AI:

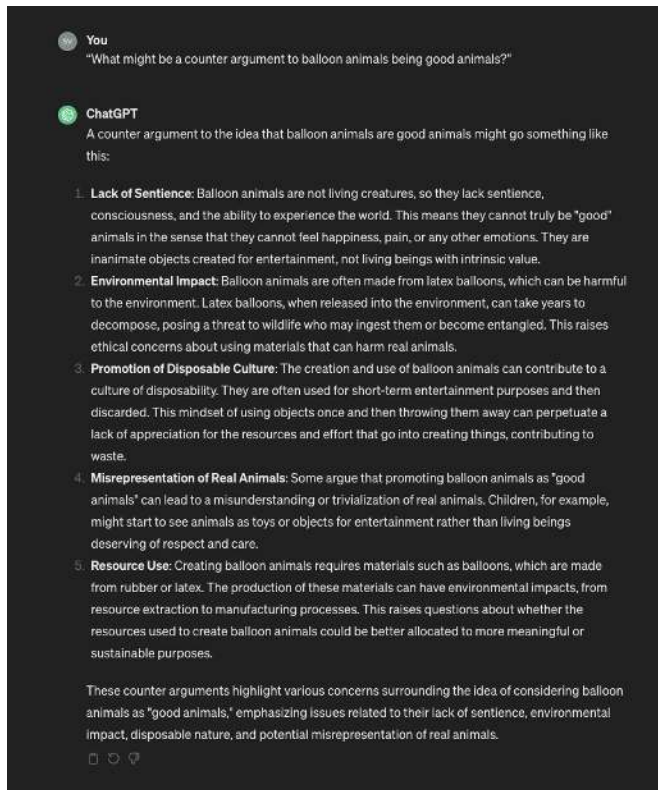
The AI generated details concerning student topics of interest will present ideas for exploration that will facilitate conversation and dialogue on social topics

Overview of Learning Activities and Tasks

TSW have crafted a thesis statement concerning their selected topic from the annotated bibliography that was previously submitted. Having understood and established their own stance on the issue, students will begin exploring an alternative point of view on their controversy.

TTW use a sample, low risk topic to guide students through the activity process. Ex: “What might be a counter argument to balloon animals being good animals?”

After the AI has generated ideas, TTW facilitate conversation around what the antithesis of each point might be. Example counter to #2: “Although some may say balloon animals are bad for the environment due to their latex construction, living animals are more devastating to the environment, consuming resources and water at alarming rates”



You
"What might be a counter argument to balloon animals being good animals?"

ChatGPT
A counter argument to the idea that balloon animals are good animals might go something like this:

1. **Lack of Sentience:** Balloon animals are not living creatures, so they lack sentience, consciousness, and the ability to experience the world. This means they cannot truly be "good" animals in the sense that they cannot feel happiness, pain, or any other emotions. They are inanimate objects created for entertainment, not living beings with intrinsic value.
2. **Environmental Impact:** Balloon animals are often made from latex balloons, which can be harmful to the environment. Latex balloons, when released into the environment, can take years to decompose, posing a threat to wildlife who may ingest them or become entangled. This raises ethical concerns about using materials that can harm real animals.
3. **Promotion of Disposable Culture:** The creation and use of balloon animals can contribute to a culture of disposability. They are often used for short-term entertainment purposes and then discarded. This mindset of using objects once and then throwing them away can perpetuate a lack of appreciation for the resources and effort that go into creating things, contributing to waste.
4. **Misrepresentation of Real Animals:** Some argue that promoting balloon animals as "good animals" can lead to a misunderstanding or trivialization of real animals. Children, for example, might start to see animals as toys or objects for entertainment rather than living beings deserving of respect and care.
5. **Resource Use:** Creating balloon animals requires materials such as balloons, which are made from rubber or latex. The production of these materials can have environmental impacts, from resource extraction to manufacturing processes. This raises questions about whether the resources used to create balloon animals could be better allocated to more meaningful or sustainable purposes.

These counter arguments highlight various concerns surrounding the idea of considering balloon animals as "good animals," emphasizing issues related to their lack of sentience, environmental impact, disposable nature, and potential misrepresentation of real animals.

Through reversing each component, the students are practicing the creation of counter arguments and rebuttals, which are essential to argument essays.

After exploration and practice of alternative points of view to the low risk topic, TTW allow students to use open source Artificial Intelligence to produce counter stances over their own topics.

TSW will then work with AI to establish potential counter arguments to their own topics, reflecting on how each point corroborates or conflicts the social justice thesis that works towards equality.

TTW guide students back to a whole class discussion on the outcomes of their AI experimentation on social justice topics.

TTW model how to cite AI

Criteria for Success

Students can refer to this checklist for their work on this lesson:

2. I used AI to help posit an alternative point of view to my thesis

4. I crafted rebuttals to the AI content

5. ____ I reflected on the content in contrast to social justice outcomes

6. ____ I cited Chat GPT as a consulted resource in my argumentative essay

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CHAPTER OVERVIEW

3: Case Studies

3.1: Case Study- "Using AI for Social Justice Counter Points" with Dual Enrollment High School Students in Tennessee

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3.1: Case Study- "Using AI for Social Justice Counter Points" with Dual Enrollment High School Students in Tennessee

Teaching Context:

This lesson was delivered to an English 102 Dual Enrollment (DE) class that takes place within a high school in the Nashville, TN area. Students are juniors or seniors, approximately 16-18 years of age. These dually enrolled students have either earned credit for the first portion of the English sequence through taking English 101 via a DE class previously, through securing a high enough ACT score, or through earning an approved score on the Advanced Placement (AP) exam. All students in this district are issued a Chromebook.

What worked:

Using AI to produce initial counters to social justice themed topics freed up class space to the actual creation of content to retort. Rather than spending time wondering what the other side might say, students were near immediately presented with the alternate point of view. By being able to begin drafting content quickly, the creation of a counter paragraph happened with greater ease, and students were also able to dedicate time to further research that might more fully explore the contrasting point of view.

What didn't work:

Expecting a singular free AI platform to meet the needs of the entire class was a bit short sighted. Between district web filters, internet connectivity issues, and matters of the like, I should have expected more conflict in this realm.

For next time:

In the future, I think providing multiple points of access initially would be best. Fortunately, students were able to pivot and suggest their own way of reaching artificial intelligence for the activity. However, the live recalibrating could have been avoided if the lesson had multiple platforms already at disposal.

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How to Contribute to this Book

We welcome and encourage any and all contributions.

In its current iteration, this text is built along a five-part inquiry process:

1. develop a formative lesson plan that uses generative AI in a manner that promotes social justice,
2. publish this lesson plan using the Lesson Plan Template,
3. test this lesson plan in class,
4. reflect on this in-class test,
5. publish this reflection as a Case Study using the Case Study Template.

We believe that this project has value as both a repository of lesson plans that focus on using generative AI to approach social justice issues in order to open conversations about the value of AI tools and as place for educators to share their experiences setting sail into these new and unsettled waters.

For potential contributors, there are many ways to contribute. You could follow all five steps outlined above, or you could stop after adding a lesson plan, or you could write a case study based on your use of one of the existing lesson plans.

Sample Lesson Plan Template

Sample Lesson Plan Template

Definition:

TTW = The Teacher Will

TSW = The Student Will

Course and Student:

(Describe the general context of the students and the course for which you anticipate implementing the lesson.)

“This lesson is intended for an English 101 composition course that consists of Dual Enrollment students, most generally between the ages of 16-18”

Time frame:

(Describe the amount of time you plan to spend on the lesson, as well as a general position for the lesson within your course - such as the unit you plan to implement the lesson.)

“This lesson will last approximately 30 minutes and will occur within the timeframe of working on our third paper, an argument”

Objectives:

(List the student learning outcomes and skills that you hope to achieve for the lesson.)

“TSW practice how to produce a counter argument”

“TSW implement close reading”

AI Tool and Other Materials/Supplies:

(List the content needed for the lesson to be successful)

“Access to the Internet. Copies of ‘Civil Disobedience.’ Paper and pencils.”

Rationale for implementation of AI to teach these standards:

(Provide insights into why the needed components are necessary. You do not need to justify the pencils and the paper, but why “Civil Disobedience” with AI?)

“Thoreau’s ‘Civil Disobedience’ is appropriate for this lesson because it fits within the greater scope of the English curriculum but also poses powerful arguments that are still relevant today. The consideration of the ‘cog in the machine’ mentality coupled with AI provides a unique learning context”

Overview of Learning Activities and Tasks

(Progress through the major movements of your lesson in a way that allows for another to view and generally understand what is necessary for the lesson's form and function)

“TSW have read ‘Civil Disobedience’ for homework.”

“TTW begin class by quoting Thoreau ‘If an injustice requires you to be the agent of injustice to another, then, I say, break the law. Let your life be a counter-friction to stop the government machine.’”

Sample Case Study Template

Section 1: Narrative Description

A brief description of your teaching context, which lesson you employed, and a narrative of the actual in-class activity.

Section 2: What Worked

A brief reflection on the aspects of the lesson that worked smoothly and the benefits your students gained.

Section 3: What Did Not Work

A brief reflection on the aspects of the lesson that did not work smoothly and the challenges your students faced.

Section 4: What Would I Do Differently Next Time?

A brief reflection on the things you would change to make this lesson more useful for your students.

Further Reading

Note: this list is not offered to suggest that this is an exhaustive or even partially complete survey of the current opinion about the state of generative AI in the classroom; rather, this list captures the first salvo of texts the creators read and discussed while working on this project.

We welcome any and all additions.

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